# Fair share and SNAP

*How SNAP shapes HarvestNet in three ways, and how to defend each one.*

> **AFTER THIS LESSON**
> You can explain the fair share and the three SNAP links, and answer "isn't asking about SNAP invasive?"

## 1. The fair share

Each household has a weekly produce amount that grows with household size, like a SNAP benefit. The current table is a placeholder: 4 lb for one person, 7 lb for two, 10 lb for three, 12 lb for four, and 2 lb more for each additional person.

The participating food banks publish the table together, and calculators apply it. It does two jobs:

- **A yardstick.** It shows which households are furthest behind.
- **A limit.** No household goes above its fair share while another at the same food bank is below it. Produce left over after everyone has their share still goes out instead of being wasted.

It never assigns produce, so it isn't a central decider (Lesson 1).

## 2. SNAP as an eligibility signal

A household can choose to say it receives SNAP/CalFresh. There's no proof required, and "prefer not to say" is always available. Food banks can use the answer under their own rules. USDA guidance lets states treat people on SNAP as automatically income-eligible for TEFAP food, and allows self-declaration.

Source: USDA FNS TEFAP memo FD-036. Rules vary by state, so check each food bank's policy.

**Proposed:** SNAP status never changes a household's fair share. Saying yes or no brings no advantage and no penalty, so nobody is pressured to disclose it.

## 3. SNAP produce programs

Farmers markets join as donors, so produce still unsold at closing time gets rescued. Pickup texts can also tell SNAP households about **Market Match**, which gives CalFresh shoppers extra money for

fruit and vegetables at participating farmers markets and other farm-direct sites in California.

Source: Ecology Center, Market Match. Check which markets near the demo region currently participate before showing any.

## Hard questions

### "Isn't asking about SNAP invasive?"

It's optional, "prefer not to say" is always offered, and it never changes what a household gets. Agents only ever see counts, and the answer is deleted when the request expires after 7 days.

### "Who picked those fair-share numbers?"

They're placeholders for the demo. In real use, the participating food banks would set and publish them together.

Source: docs/MVP_DESIGN.md, section 4, and ADR 0009.

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**Read next:** docs/MVP_DESIGN.md, section 4 (The SNAP connection), then the Market Match page.

**Previous:** Lesson 3: The agents and what each one wants · **Next:** Lesson 5: Produce profiles and matching

Quick lookup: HarvestNet at a glance.

Anything unclear? Ask me. I'm your teacher for this, and I can re-explain any part in different words.

Source of truth: docs/MVP_DESIGN.md, CONTEXT.md, and docs/adr/. If this lesson and those disagree, they win.